RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE: NATURE AND OBJECT

FOUR LAYERS → DATED ANCHORS → JAMES'S MARKS → JAMES'S METHOD AND VARIETIES → OTTO'S NUMINOUS → STACE AGAINST ZAEHNER → MEDIATION → ADVAITA → RADHAKRISHNAN AND VEDANTIC PLURALITY → FOUR INDIAN STRUCTURES → SACRED, HOLY AND GOD → VERIDICALITY → ALSTON → REVELATION, PRAYER, WORSHIP AND PUBLIC DISCOURSE → ANSWER SPINE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final synthesis. Each card uses a layout chosen for its own content; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW
● SUBORDINATE EXTRA
● APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 THE CLAUSE, THE FOUR LAYERS AND THE THREE ILLEGITIMATE JUMPS

PHENOMENOLOGY
CLAIMED OBJECT
INTERPRETATION
EPISTEMIC FORCE
SUBJECTIVE = FIRST-PERSONAL, NOT UNREAL
INEFFABLE = RESISTS ADEQUATE EXPRESSION
NEURAL CORRELATE = MEDIATION

SYLLABUS CLAUSE, VERBATIM

- Religious Experience : Nature and Object (Indian and Western).
- Owns phenomenology, typology, claimed object, interpretation and epistemic force; owns prayer and worship because of the 2020 question, and the sacred/holy as the object-pole.

THREE ILLEGITIMATE JUMPS

- A. intensity to truth: 'it felt overwhelming, therefore it was veridical'.
- B. naming to meeting: 'my tradition calls it God, therefore God was met'.
- C. mediation to fabrication: 'it has a neural correlate, therefore it is nothing'.

THREE DIFFERENT ACHIEVEMENTS

- Psychological genuineness: the subject is sincere and not deceived about having the state.
- Doctrinal authenticity: the state conforms to what the tradition recognises.
- Metaphysical veridicality: the claimed object exists and was met.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Winning one of the three achievements does not win the others, which is why the four layers must be separated before any verdict is offered.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious experience may transform the subject completely and still not convert that private force into public proof of the reality it appears to disclose.

01

STAGE 01 DATED PRINT ANCHORS AND THE ORDER OF THE ARGUMENT

JAMES 1902
DURKHEIM 1912
OTTO 1917
RADHAKRISHNAN 1927
ZAEHNER 1957 / ELIADE 1957
STACE 1960
KATZ 1978 / STUMP 1979
ALSTON 1991
CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY AN INVENTED YEAR

1902 James, The Varieties of Religious Experience (Gifford Lectures 1901-02) → **1912 Durkheim, The Elementary Forms of Religious Life -> the sacred against the profane** → **1917 Otto, The Idea of the Holy -> the numinous supplies the object-pole James left open** → **1927 Radhakrishnan, The Hindu View of Life -> the named work of the 2025 question** → **1957 Zaehner, Mysticism Sacred and Profane; 1957 Eliade, The Sacred and the Profane**

1960 Stace, Mysticism and Philosophy -> answers Zaehner with a common core → **1971 Rachels; 1978 Katz -> answers the common core; Forman answers Katz** → **1979 Stump, Petitionary Prayer; 1991 Alston, Perceiving God**

WHY THE CLAUSE EXISTS

- A first-personal report is delivered; its felt certainty is not transferable as it stands.
- The subject's tradition supplies the concepts that name what was met.
- Other traditions report incompatible objects with equal conviction, and every candidate test assesses authenticity rather than existence.

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY A MANUFACTURED YEAR

- Schleiermacher, The Christian Faith; Swinburne, The Existence of God; Hick, Philosophy of Religion.
- Forman, The Problem of Pure Consciousness; Aquinas, Summa Theologiae; Teresa of Avila; Habermas on the translation proviso.
- Brhadaranyaka Upanisad 1.4.10; Taittiriya Upanisad 2.4.1; the navadha bhakti list.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Otto answers James, Stace answers Zaehner, Katz answers the common core and Forman answers Katz, so the order of publication is itself the structure of the debate.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Getting the sequence of these dated works right is what turns a list of names into an argument with a direction.

02

STAGE 02 WILLIAM JAMES: THE MARKS OF MYSTICAL STATES, GRADED TWO-PLUS-TWO

INEFFABILITY — DEFINING
NOETIC QUALITY — DEFINING
TRANSIENCY — USUAL
PASSIVITY — USUAL
MARKS OF MYSTICAL STATES ONLY
AUTHORITY FOR THE SUBJECT, NONE OVER OUTSIDERS
THE FLAT FOUR-MARK LIST IS THE COMMONEST ERROR

DEFINING: ineffability, the 'handiest' mark — the state defies expression and must be directly experienced

DEFINING: noetic quality — 'states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect' → **USUAL: transiency — cannot be sustained long, though it may recur and develop** → **USUAL: passivity — voluntary preliminaries may facilitate onset, then the mystic feels grasped and held**

WHY THE GRADING PAYS IN THE EXAM

- Because transiency is only usual, a stable and established liberating knowledge (jnana) still counts as mystical.
- A flat four-mark list defines Advaitic realisation out of the category and destroys the Indian comparison the paper rewards.

SCOPE AND AUTHORITY

- The four marks describe mystical states, not every religious experience.
- James holds the states authoritative for the one who has them and denies them any authority over outsiders, which is the hinge of the veridicality question.

OBJECTION AND REPLY

- Objection: ineffability and noetic quality look inconsistent — how can a state be beyond expression and a state of knowledge?
- Reply: ineffability concerns the adequacy of report while noetic quality concerns the mode of presentation, exactly as an unfamiliar taste presents a determinate quality one cannot fully convey.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Two marks settle the classification and two merely accompany it, so the class is decoupled from duration and receptivity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: James's four marks are not four equals: ineffability and noetic quality settle the classification, while transiency and passivity merely accompany it.

03

STAGE 03 JAMES'S METHOD, MEDICAL MATERIALISM, FRUITS AND THE VARIETIES

EMPIRICAL AND PRAGMATIC
MEDICAL MATERIALISM — REFUSED
FRUITS — ACCEPTED
MATTHEW 7:16/20 — ADOPTED, NOT COINED
THE 'MORE' THROUGH THE SUBCONSCIOUS
PERSONAL BEFORE INSTITUTIONAL

HEALTHY-MINDEDNESS: religion of the once-born; evil minimised, harmony affirmed → **THE SICK SOUL: acute consciousness of evil, guilt and finitude** → **THE DIVIDED SELF -> CONVERSION: orientation and conduct reorganised** → **SAINTLINESS: the durable moral and affective fruits** → **MYSTICISM: the experiential pole, carrying the four graded marks**

THE TEST HE REFUSES

- Medical materialism is James's own term in Lecture I for discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin.
- Causal origin does not by itself settle truth or worth; the same argument would discredit every insight that arrived to a tired or unusual brain.

THE TEST HE ACCEPTS

- Enduring moral integration, courage, charity and transformed conduct.
- 'By their fruits ye shall know them' is Matthew 7:16/20; James adopts the maxim as a criterion and does not coin it.

THE OBJECT HE ALLOWS HIMSELF

- The self feels connected, through the subconscious, with a wider reality he calls the 'MORE'.
- It is deliberately under-described, so that the psychology does not smuggle in a theology.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Refusing origin-based dismissal and accepting consequence-based assessment together license an empirical study of religion that is not reductive.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: James judges religion by its fruits rather than by its roots, and the price of that method is that it authenticates a transformation without establishing the reality of the 'MORE'.

04

STAGE 04 OTTO'S NUMINOUS AND SCHLEIERMACHER'S ABSOLUTE DEPENDENCE

MYSTERIUM — WHOLLY OTHER
TREMENDUM — AWEFULNESS, MAJESTAS, ENERGY
FASCINANS — ATTRACTS WHILE IT TERRIFIES
CREATURE-FEELING
NON-RATIONAL IS NOT IRRATIONAL
SCHEMATISATION COMES AFTERWARDS
FEELING OF ABSOLUTE DEPENDENCE

THE HOLY splits into a NON-RATIONAL CORE (the numinous) and a LATER RATIONAL-MORAL SCHEMATISATION

mysterium: not merely unknown but incommensurable with ordinary categories → **tremendum: awefulness, overpoweringness (majestas) and energy -> creature-feeling** → **fascinans: it attracts, entrances and beatifies even while it terrifies**

THE ARGUMENT

- Ordinary moral predicates do not exhaust holiness; religious awe displays a distinctive quality disclosed in experience.
- Goodness and justice are applied to the holy afterwards, in schematisation, and are therefore a second operation on a prior datum.

SCHLEIERMACHER, AND WHY OTTO CORRECTS HIM

- For Schleiermacher, in The Christian Faith, the essence of religion is the feeling of absolute dependence.
- Dependence describes the subject's own condition, whereas the numinous is constituted by its directedness to a wholly other.

OBJECTION, REPLY AND THE REAL LIMIT

- Objection: psychology can explain awe without any numinous object, so Otto has reified a culturally trained emotion.
- Reply: he describes the intentional structure of the state, and intentionality is a form rather than an extra feeling — but description is not existence.
- Limit: Indian traditions often organise the sacred through purity and auspiciousness rather than dread, which restricts Otto's cross-cultural claim.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Non-rational means not reducible to conceptual and moral judgement, and Otto explicitly denies that it means contrary to reason.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Otto shows that the holy is not the morally good raised to a maximum but a distinct category with its own phenomenology, disclosed in an awe no ethical predicate exhausts.

05

STAGE 05 STACE AGAINST ZAEHNER: TWO TYPOLOGIES, OPPOSITE ANSWERS

EXTROVERTIVE / INTROVERTIVE
FIVE SHARED MARKS
COMMON CORE — PERENNIALISM
NATURE / MONISTIC / THEISTIC
NO COMMON CORE
CONFESSIONAL RANKING — CRITICISED
KEEP THE CLASSIFICATIONS, DROP THE RANKING

STACE'S FIVE SHARED MARKS

- A sense of objectivity or reality; blessedness and peace; a feeling of the holy or sacred; paradoxicality; ineffability.
- They are reported within the descriptions, not imposed on them afterwards.

OBJECTIONS ON BOTH SIDES

- Against Stace: 'interpretation' is doing all the work, since subtracting enough of it makes any two experiences look alike.
- Against Zaehner: the typology smuggles in a theological ranking, which can be dropped while the classification is retained.

WHAT SURVIVES THE DISPUTE

- Monistic and theistic reports differ in logical form: identity abolishes one term, relation requires two.
- A common-core theory must explain that difference away rather than assume it.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The two schemes are rivals answering opposite questions, so merging them into one typology destroys the disagreement this topic exists to examine.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Stace buys cross-cultural unity by relegating difference to interpretation while Zaehner preserves difference at the price of a contested hierarchy.

06

STAGE 06 MEDIATION: KATZ, FORMAN, ATTRIBUTION AND PLURAL MEDIATION

NO UNMEDIATED EXPERIENCES
PURE CONSCIOUSNESS EVENT
ATTRIBUTION
PLURAL MEDIATION OF ONE REAL
MEDIATION IS NOT FABRICATION
IT DEFEATS THE CONVERGENCE INFERENCE

POSITION	CLAIM	PRESSURE ON IT
Perennial core (Stace)	traditions interpret a substantially shared experiential core	subtracting interpretation may manufacture an abstract sameness
Constructivism (Katz 1978)	concepts, expectations and practices shape the experience itself	contentless or minimally conceptual states pressure the universal claim
Attribution (Proudfoot-style)	an experience is religious partly because the subject explains it religiously	explaining the classification may not exhaust phenomenology or object
Plural mediation (Hick)	diverse traditions are culturally conditioned responses to one Real	an unknowable Real may be too indeterminate to support specific claims

WHAT MEDIATION ACTUALLY DEFEATS

- It removes the inference from cross-cultural convergence to a single shared object.
- It does not remove the occurrence, because all ordinary perception is mediated by concepts, expectation and training and remains perception.

THE DISCIPLINED CONCLUSION

- Separate occurrence, interpretation and veridicality, and argue each on its own evidence.
- Comparative work can continue as the study of tradition-shaped experience-types; only the perennialist inferential step is lost.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Constructivism attacks an inference rather than the reports, so it erodes the convergence argument without showing that anything was fabricated.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Constructivism is strongest exactly where mystical reports are richest and weakest exactly where they are emptiest, which is why the dispute now rests on the contentless case.

07

STAGE 07 ADVAITA: SIX FEATURES OF IMMEDIATE REALISATION

NON-DUAL (NIRVIKALPA)
IDENTITY, NOT RELATION
SELF-ESTABLISHED (SVATAH-SIDDHA)
BEYOND OBJECTIFYING SPEECH (AVACYA)
BLISS (ANANDA)
STABLE KNOWLEDGE (JNANA)
ANIRVACANIYA BELONGS TO MAYA

1. Non-dual (nirvikalpa): subject-object duality collapses — against theistic mysticism, where two terms remain

2. Identity, not relation: 'I am Brahman' (aham brahmasmi), Brhadaranyaka Upanisad 1.4.10 — against Otto's wholly other → **3. Self-established (svatah-siddha): self-luminous consciousness needs no further cognition — against James's merely felt authority** → **4. Beyond objectifying speech (avacya): 'from which words turn back' — a claim about structure, not a reporting difficulty**

THE ROUTE AND THE IMAGE

- Hearing (sravana) -> reflection (manana) -> contemplation (nididhyasana) -> realisation.
- The tenth man: instruction does not create the missing person but removes ignorance of an already present fact.

THE TERMINOLOGICAL FIREWALL

- Anirvacaniya, 'indescribable as either real or unreal' (sad-asad-vilaksana), is the status of maya and the world-appearance.
- It is never the status of Brahman or of Brahman-realisation, and importing it here is a scripted error.

OBJECTION, REPLY AND THE PRICE

- Objection: a contentless experience cannot identify Brahman.
- Reply: Brahman is the self rather than an inferred object, and instruction prepares a non-objective recognition.
- Price: the state leaves the space of ordinary evidence, so it cannot be re-entered as public evidence for Brahman.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Subject-object cognition presupposes a witnessing consciousness that is never itself an object, which is why the realisation is recognition rather than presentation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Advaitic realisation is not a subject perceiving Brahman but the removal of the ignorance that made subject and object look like two.

08

STAGE 08 RADHAKRISHNAN AND THE PLURALITY OF THE VEDANTIC TRADITION

INTEGRAL INTUITION
EXPERIENCE PRIMARY, DOGMA SECONDARY
SELF-CERTIFYING
THE HINDU VIEW OF LIFE, 1927
ADVAITIC ASSIMILATION — THE CHARGE
SANKARA / RAMANUJA / MADHVA

THREE CLAIMS AND THREE PRESSURES

- Experience is primary — but an experience prior to all creeds can be corrected by none.
- It is self-certifying — but self-certification is exactly what an outsider cannot check.
- It is universal — but 'one depth, many readings' is itself a substantive metaphysics that theists and Buddhists reject.

THE VEDANTIC TRADITION IS NOT ONE VOICE

- Sankara: non-objective recognition of identity, where subject-object duality belongs to ignorance.
- Ramanuja: Brahman is personal, selves and world are real dependent modes, and fulfilment is communion in which the worshipper is not dissolved.
- Madhva: God and soul remain eternally different, and saving experience is a grace-enabled relation.

THE COMMON TEST

- Every school assesses the experience soteriologically: does it remove ignorance, egoism and bondage?
- That is what distinguishes Vedantic anubhava from an unregulated private impression.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Reply to the assimilation charge is that universality concerns experiential depth rather than identical doctrinal description, and its adequacy remains contested.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Radhakrishnan inverts the usual order of religion so that dogma does not generate experience but experience generates dogma.

09

STAGE 09 THE FOUR INDIAN STRUCTURES AND THEIR TERMINI

IDENTITY
ISOLATION
RELATION AND GRACE
INSIGHT
FOUR DIFFERENT LOGICAL FORMS
NO SINGLE 'INDIAN MYSTICISM'

TRADITION	EXPERIENCE-STRUCTURE AND TERMINUS	CONTROL
Advaita	non-dual recognition through hearing, reflection and contemplation; terminus is the self as Brahman	not an encounter between two independently existing terms
Yoga	staged concentration culminating in seedless absorption; terminus is isolated consciousness (purusa)	Yoga's special Lord is not the creator-object of every experience
Devotional traditions	love, surrender, remembrance, prayer and worship; terminus is a personal Lord	relation and grace remain real and must not be redescribed as Advaitic identity
Buddhism	insight into impermanence, no-permanent-self and conditioned arising; terminus is Dharma and cessation (nirvana)	claims remain tradition-mediated, and the very category of an object may mislead

PRESSURE ON THE WESTERN TYPOLOGIES

- Zaehner's monistic and theistic pair has no comfortable slot for Buddhist insight, where there is no absolute to be identical with and no person to relate to.
- Stace's introvertive type must treat each tradition's own account of its terminus as mere interpretation, which is precisely Katz's objection.

OBJECTION AND REPLY

- Objection: these are four doctrinal descriptions rather than four experiences, so the difference may live entirely in the theology.
- Reply: the practices, preconditions and reported transformations also differ, so concede the mediation and refuse the reduction.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — This table is a bridge for the present clause, and complete school metaphysics remains with the relevant Paper I owners.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: There is no single Indian mysticism, because identity, isolation, relation and insight are four different logical structures with four different termini.

10

STAGE 10 SACRED, HOLY AND GOD: THE GENUS AND ITS PARADIGM SPECIES

OTTO — THE HOLY
DURKHEIM 1912 — THE SACRED
ELIADE 1957 — HIEROPHANY
NON-THEISTIC RELIGIONS HAVE A SACRED
GOD AS SOURCE AND MEASURE
HOLY IS NOT SACRED
SOTERIOLOGICAL REQUIREMENT

THE DISCRIMINATOR THAT EARNS MARKS

- Otto's holy is a phenomenological quality of an object; Durkheim's sacred is a social classification.
- A candidate who treats them as one word misses the strongest objection to each.

INDIAN PARITY

- Pure (pavitra, suddha), auspicious (mangala), meritorious (punya), crossing-place (tirtha), sacred field (ksetra), temple (devalaya).
- Sacred time in parvan days, muhurta and the ritual calendar; and the Veda's sanctity as authorless — sanctity without a sanctifier.

TWO OBJECTIONS AND THEIR REPLIES

- Over-breadth: flags, nations and clubs would qualify. Reply: add the soteriological requirement, that the sacred is what the human predicament is diagnosed and resolved in relation to.
- Subordination: making God a species of a wider genus offends the theist. Reply: the subordination is conceptual, for comparative definition, and not ontological.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — The 2018 stem grants the generic category and asks about the specific one, so the answer must be given in degrees rather than as a flat yes or no.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: The sacred is the genus and God is theism's paradigm species of it, which is why God can be an object of religion but cannot define one.

11

STAGE 11 VERIDICALITY: CREDULITY, TESTIMONY AND THE DEFEATER LEDGER

PRINCIPLE OF CREDULITY
PRINCIPLE OF TESTIMONY
PRIMA FACIE, NOT ULTIMA FACIE
NATURALISM — LOUDEST, WEAKEST
DIVERSITY — QUIETEST, STRONGEST
FRUITS AUTHENTICATE, THEY DO NOT PROVE
UNRELIABILITY BURDEN

FOR: if it seems to a subject that X is present, then probably X is, absent defeaters; testimony extends this to the hearer → **FOR: the noetic quality of the state, and the convergence of mystics across traditions** → **AGAINST: naturalistic explanation — projection and wish-fulfilment, social formation, neural mediation** → **AGAINST: unreliable conditions — drugs, pathology, suggestion, deprivation** → **AGAINST: diversity — a personal God, non-dual Brahman and emptiness reported with equal conviction**

THE BURDEN CLAUSE MOST SCRIPTS MISS

- A causal or neural correlation is not automatically an epistemic defeat.
- The critic must show that the mechanism is unreliable, or that it fully explains the seeming without the proposed object.

FOUR CRITICISMS AND THEIR REPLIES

- Naturalism: origin does not by itself falsify content. Conflicting objects: interpretation may vary while contact is common, though this reply can become unfalsifiable.
- Ineffability: it limits exhaustiveness, not every statement. Moral fruits: a criterion of authenticity, not a deductive proof of the object.

THE BALANCE TO WRITE

- Prima facie, defeasible warrant for the subject, plus testimonial weight for the hearer, minus public demonstration of the object.
- Diversity outranks neurology because it needs only incompatibility, whereas naturalism must additionally discharge the unreliability burden.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different things, and saying so is the most efficient single sentence available in this clause.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious experience confers prima facie justification on the subject and testimonial weight on the hearer without establishing its object publicly.

12

STAGE 12 ALSTON'S PERCEPTUAL MODEL AND ITS EXACT CONCLUSION

THEORY OF APPEARING
M-PERCEPTION AND M-BELIEFS
DOXASTIC PRACTICE
EPISTEMIC CIRCULARITY
PRACTICAL RATIONALITY, NOT PROOF
DIVERSITY — HIS OWN CONCESSION
RATIONALLY 'SIT TIGHT'

1 Perception is something presenting itself to a subject; sensory content is not essential to that structure → **2 Mystical perception shares the structure: an apparent object, a mode of presentation and a resulting belief** → **3 Beliefs are formed within socially established doxastic practices with their own override procedures** → **4 No doxastic practice can be shown reliable without circularity, sense perception and memory included** → **5 We are nonetheless practically rational in engaging in sense perception**

6 Therefore engagement in an established religious practice is practically rational, absent reason to think it unreliable

WHAT IS AND IS NOT CLAIMED

- Claimed: prima facie justification for M-beliefs, and the practical rationality of engaging in the practice.
- Not claimed: proof that the practice is reliable, or ultima facie justification.

THE OBJECTIONS HE FACES

- Diversity, which he himself calls the most serious: incompatible established practices cannot all be tracking one reality.
- Lack of cross-checking and prediction, answered by the internal override systems of discernment criteria, doctrinal tests and spiritual direction.

KEEP HIM APART FROM SWINBURNE

- Swinburne's principle of credulity is a general epistemic principle about seemings.
- Alston's argument is about socially established practices and their parity with sense perception.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Alston shifts the burden onto the sceptic to show what makes religious practice relevantly worse than sense perception rather than merely demanding non-circular proof.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Alston earns religious practice immunity from a self-defeating demand rather than a superior warrant, and an honest answer stops exactly where he stops.

13

STAGE 13 REVELATION, PRAYER, WORSHIP AND PUBLIC DISCOURSE

VEHICLE, NOT CARGO
ADDRESS AGAINST ASCRIPTION OF WORTH
A-C-T-S
AQUINAS' SECONDARY CAUSE
STUMP 1979 / RACHELS 1971
VITARAGA / APURVA / UPASANA
TRANSLATION PROVISO
AUTHENTICITY, NOT TRUTH

REVELATION: a unitive state may carry no disclosure-claim, and truths may be held revealed with no unitive state — so the two are not identical

SIGNIFICANCE: origin, renewal, and the risk of unchecked private authority, which is why discernment exists → **PRAYER is address and presupposes a responsive God; WORSHIP is ascription of supreme worth and presupposes only a supremely valuable reality** → **PUBLIC DISCOURSE: description, coherence, discernment norms, fruits, disciplined replicability and doxastic practices**

THE TWO PHILOSOPHICAL PROBLEMS

- Petition: an omniscient, perfectly good and immutable God makes petition idle. Aquinas replies that we obtain what God has determined shall be obtained through prayer; Stump replies that asking protects the relationship.
- Worship: Rachels argues that worship entails unconditional obedience and that autonomy forbids abdication. Replies: worship recognises worth, a perfectly good being's commands coincide with moral judgement, and the autonomy assumed is atomistic.

THE INDIAN CASES THAT DECIDE IT

- Jainism: the Tirthankara is free of passion (vitaraga) and cannot respond, so image-veneration is worship without answerable petition.
- Mimamsa: efficacy lies in the unseen potency (apurva) and the deity is a grammatical dative in the injunction.
- Advaita: contemplative worship (upasana) is efficacious at the everyday level and transcended, not repudiated, at the ultimate level.

THE LINE IN THE PUBLIC-DISCOURSE ANSWER

- All six criteria are publicly assessable and all six test authenticity rather than truth; concede this explicitly.
- Habermas allows full religious expression in the informal public sphere subject to a translation proviso before formal state decision-making.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — A religion can survive the loss of petition but none survives the loss of worship, because nothing would then mark the ultimate as ultimate.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Prayer presupposes a responsive ultimate while worship presupposes only a supremely valuable one, and religious experience is publicly discussable while remaining privately probative.

14

STAGE 14 THE ANSWER SPINE, THE VERDICT LADDER AND THE PYQ ROUTE

ONE PART IN EVERY PAPER, 2018-2025
NATURE HALF AND OBJECT HALF
ENCOUNTERED OR REALISED
SIX OF EIGHT STEMS ARE DOUBLE-BARRELLED
NAME THE DEFEATER
GRADED VERDICT, NEVER A SUMMARY

Name the LAYER the stem is on, then define the experience → **State the account with its decisive discrimination, and identify the claimed object** → **Say whether the object is encountered (relation) or realised (identity)** → **Apply credulity, testimony and the defeaters, ranking diversity above neurology** → **Run one Indian-Western axis to its discriminating point**

Give the strongest objection by name, then the reply → **Close with a graded verdict and the defeater that would overturn it**

THE EIGHT PRINTED QUESTIONS

- 2018 Q7(a) 20m sacred and holy as generic names, and God as object; 2019 Q7(c) 15m public discourse; 2020 Q7(b) 15m prayer and worship.
- 2021 Q7(c) 15m the Vedantic tradition; 2022 Q7(c) 15m James on nature and variety; 2023 Q8(c) 15m mystical experience and revelation.
- 2024 Q8(c) 15m the main features according to Advaita Vedanta; 2025 Q8(a) 20m Radhakrishnan in The Hindu View of Life.

THE TOP BAND

- Graded marks, identity against relation, the credulity and defeater apparatus, and Indian parity argued rather than asserted.
- Plus one discriminating distinction: defining against usual marks, Otto's holy against Durkheim's sacred, constructivism against the Pure Consciousness Event, or prima facie against ultima facie.

STANDING PENALTIES

- An ungraded four-mark list; an unanswered second deliverable; a verdict that summarises instead of deciding.
- Any invented year for Schleiermacher, Swinburne, Hick, Forman or Teresa.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — Directive fidelity is graded before content, so decoding the printed instruction is worth more than any additional thinker added to the script.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Every question in this clause has a nature half and an object half, and saying whether the object is encountered or realised separates a good script from an average one.

E

EXTRA SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

PERCEPTUAL MODEL AGAINST CONSTRUCTIVISM
PERENNIAL CORE AGAINST HARD DIVERSITY
NEURO-REDUCTION AGAINST EMBODIMENT
NON-DUAL AWARENESS AGAINST ENCOUNTER

FOUR SECOND-ORDER CONTRASTS

- Perceptual model against constructivism: mediation does not by itself erase objectivity, since expert perception is heavily trained and remains perception.
- Perennial core against hard diversity: retreat to family resemblance or analogous transformation rather than identity of content.
- Neuro-reduction against non-reductive embodiment: causal mechanism and truth-value are distinct questions, as in ordinary perception.
- Non-dual awareness against intentional encounter: doctrine prepares and interprets the recognition, while the liberating moment itself is non-objective.

HOW MUCH TO USE

- One advanced move in a fifteen-marker, or one to two in a twenty-marker, and only after the owner's own material is on the page.
- Prayer and worship, public discourse, the sacred and the holy, the Stace and Zaehner typology and the perceptual model are Core and are taught in the main sessions.

OPTIONAL STATUS — Everything on this card is optional enrichment and is unnecessary for a competent core answer.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels